Othello

By William Shakespeare

INTRODUCTION

Othello can be regarded as Shakespeare's greatest lover. Whilst other plays have waxed and waned in popularity, Othello has remained universally acclaimed since its first performance back in 1604. From its inter-racial marriage theme, to the fatal flaw that mars the character of many . . . Othello is an epic tale of manipulation, passion and sorrow. It is, therefore, regarded as one of the finest literary works, and Shakespeare's greatest tragedy.

We find Othello and his bride Desdemona alone in their bedchamber. Othello's first lieutenant, Iago has masterfully manipulated events and perceptions to achieve this chilling confrontation. We've prepared . . . Othello by William Shakespeare.

OTHELLO: It is the cause, it is the cause, my soul.
Let me not mane it to you, you chaste stars.
Ti is the cause. Yet I'll not shed her blood,
Nor scar that whiter skin of hers than snow,
And smooth as monumental alabaster.
Yet she must die, else she'll betray more men.
Put out the light, and then put out the light.
If I quench thee, thou flaming minister,
I can again thy former light restore
Should I repent me. But once put out thy light,
Thou cunning'st pattern of excelling nature,
I know not where is that Promethean heat
That can thy former light relume.
When I have plucked (the) Rose,
I cannot give it vital growth again.
It needs must wither. I'll smell (it) on the tree.
O balmy breath, that dost almost persuade
Justice to break her sword! {He kisses her}
One more, one more.
Be thus when thou art dead, and I will kill thee
And love thee after.
One more, and (this) the last.

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(He kisses her)
So sweet was ne'er so fatal. I must weep,
But they are cruel tears. This sorrow's heavenly:
It strikes where it doth love. She wakes.

DESDEMONA: Who's there? Othello?

OTHELLO: Aye, Desdemona.

DESDEMONA: Will you come to bed, my lord?

OTHELLO: Have you prayed tonight, Desdemona?

DESDEMONA: Aye, my lord.

OTHELLO: If you bethink yourself of any crime
Unreconciled as yet to heaven and grace,
Solicit for it straight.

DESDEMONA: Alack, my lord,
What may you mean by that?

OTHELLO: Well, do it, and be brief. I will walk by.
I would not kill thy unprepared spirit.
No, (heaven) forfend! I would not kill thy soul.

DESDEMONA: Talk you of killing?

OTHELLO: Aye, I do.

DESDEMONA: Then heaven have mercy on me.

OTHELLO: Amen, with all my heart.

DESDEMONA: If you say (so) I hope you will not kill me.
And yet I fear you, for you're fatal then
When your eyes roll so. Why I should fear I know not,

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Since guiltiness I know not, but yet I feel I fear.

OTHELLO: Think on thy sins.

DESDEMONA: They are loves I bear to you.

OTHELLO: Ay, and for that thou shall die.

DESDEMONA: That death's unnatural that kills for loving.
Alas, why gnaw you so your nether lip?
Some bloody passion shakes your very frame.
These are portents, but yet I hope, I hope
They do not point on me.

OTHELLO: Peace, and be still.

DESDEMONA: I will so. What's the matter?

OTHELLO: That handkerchief
Which I so loved, and gave thee, thou gav'st Cassio.

DESDEMONA: No, by my life and soul!
Send for the man, ask him.

OTHELLO: Sweet soul, take heed, take heed of perjury.
Thou art on thy deathbed.

DESDEMONA: Ay, but not yet to die.

OTHELLO: Presently.
Therefore confess thee freely of thy sin.
For to deny each article with oath
Cannot remove nor choke the strong conception
That I do groan withal. Thou art to die.

DESDEMONA: Then Lord have mercy on me!

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OTHELLO: I say "Amen."

DESDEMONA: And have you mercy, too. I never did
Offend you in my life, never loved Cassio
But with such general warranty of heaven
As I might love. I never gave him token.

OTHELLO: By heaven, I saw my handkerchief in 's hand!
O perjured woman, thou dost stone my heart
And mak'st me call what I intend to do
A murder, which I thought a sacrifice!
I saw the handkerchief!

DESDEMONA: He found it, then.
I never gave it him. Send for him hither.
Let him confess a truth.

OTHELLO: He hath confessed.

DESDEMONA: What, my lord?

OTHELLO: That he hath used thee.

DESDEMONA: How? Unlawfully?

OTHELLO: Aye

DESDEMONA: He will not say so.

OTHELLO: No. His mouth is stopped.
Honest Iago hath ta'en order for 't.

DESDEMONA: O, my fear interprets. What, is he dead?

OTHELLO: Had all his hairs been lives, my great revenge
Had stomach for them all.

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DESDEMONA: Alas, he is betrayed and I undone. {she weeps}

OTHELLO: Out, strumpet! Weep'st thou for him to my face?

DESDEMONA: Banish me, my lord, but kill me not!

OTHELLO: Down strumpet!

DESDEMONA: Kill me tomorrow, let me live tonight.

OTHELLO: Nay, if you strive –

DESDEMONA: But half an hour!

OTHELLO: Being done there is no pause.

DESDEMONA: But while I say one prayer!

OTHELLO: It is too late. {He smothers her}
What noise is this?—Not dead? Not yet quite dead?
I that am cruel am yet merciful.
I would not have thee linger in thy pain.
So, so.
Who's there?
Yes. 'Tis Emilia.—By and by.—She's dead.
'Tis like she comes to speak of Cassio's death.
The noise was here. Ha, no more moving?
Still as the grave. Shall she come in? Were 't good?
I think she stirs again. No. What's best to do?
If she come in, she'll sure speak to my wife.
My wife, my wife! What wife? I have no wife.

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